

A FREE MINI-BOOK FOR PARENTS WHO TRAVEL WITH KIDS

THE GPS METHOD.

Why family trips are so hard - and what actually works.

THE GPS METHOD

- G** GET CURIOUS - Before you arrive
- P** PLAY THE STOP - While you're there
- S** SAVE THE MEMORY - Before it fades

RoamUs

A parent. Father of Avir & Aarit · roamus.app

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

A Note from a Parent

This book is short on purpose.

Not because the topic is simple — travelling with kids is one of the genuinely hard things families navigate — but because you're probably reading this while someone is asleep in the next room and you have maybe twenty minutes before you need to be asleep too.

So here's what this is: about thirty-five pages, seven chapters, one framework. No fluff. No ten-step systems. No advice from someone who has never had a toddler refuse to leave a water fountain.

I'm not a parenting expert or a travel writer. I'm a dad who has spent three years testing ideas about family travel on my own kids — Avir, who is seven and wants to be a paleontologist, and Aarit, who is almost four and treats every 'do not touch' sign as a personal challenge.

I should also say: none of this would have worked without my wife Sonal, who is the one who actually makes trips survivable. While I was busy researching volcanoes and building frameworks, she was finding restaurants with actual high chairs, mapping parks near every hotel, and packing snacks with the precision of someone who knows exactly what happens when there are no snacks. I get to write the book. She did the work that made the trips possible.

What I know about this topic, I learned from my family. Sometimes from the trips that worked. More often from the ones that didn't.

The framework in this book is called the GPS Method. Three steps — Get Curious, Play the Stop, Save the Memory. It works whether you're flying internationally or driving two hours to a state park on a Saturday. You don't need an app. You don't need a big budget.

Read this. Try three things on your next trip. See what happens.

*— A parent, still figuring it out
Father of Avir & Aarit*

CHAPTER 01

The Trip We Almost Didn't Take Again

Jaipur. Hawaii. How this book started.

Two years ago, my family went to Jaipur.

Avir was five. Aarit was eighteen months, that age where they have one speed (toward danger) and one volume (loud). My wife and I had been planning for months. She'd found a hotel with a pool near the fort, bookmarked three restaurants with actual high chairs, and identified a park we could escape to if things went sideways. I had colour-coded the itinerary. We were, in our different ways, ready.

What neither of us was ready for was spending forty-five minutes of our Amber Fort visit negotiating with Aarit about a water fountain. Not the fort — a water fountain near the entrance, the kind you find in every park in every city in the world. He kept touching the spout. Walking away. Coming back. Touching it again.

Avir, meanwhile, had drifted toward a man selling chai from a cart nearby and was absorbed in watching the milk froth. He didn't want chai. He just wanted to watch. For a very long time. I wish I captured that moment in pictures, but it's etched in my memory forever.

My wife and I kept exchanging looks that parents develop - the one that says I love these children and also what is happening right now.

We did eventually see the fort. Heard the guide explain the Sheesh Mahal — the mirror palace — how a single candle could light the entire room. Avir listened for ninety seconds, then asked if the mirrors were made from the same material as the bathroom mirror at home.

That was the extent of his engagement with five hundred years of Rajput architecture.

That evening I scrolled through the photos. Forty-something pictures of walls and archways. A blurry one of the chai cart. Three photos of the water fountain. Zero pictures of my kids experiencing anything. We ordered room service and put on cartoons.

I've told this story to enough parents to know it's not unusual. Different city, different kids, different ages — same ending. Room service. Screens. That strange mix of gratitude and guilt.

The trip wasn't broken because the kids were difficult. It was broken because they were passengers. On my trip.

Eighteen months later, I started planning a trip to the Big Island of Hawaii. Expensive. Far. And for the first time, I didn't just think about logistics — I thought about what this trip could actually mean for my kids.



Avir exploring a lava tube in Hawaii. The same curiosity that makes every trip worth taking.

Avir, now almost seven, had become obsessed with geography. Volcanoes, fossils, cloud forests, ocean depths. He wanted to be a paleontologist. He could explain the difference between shield volcanoes and stratovolcanoes. He asked questions about Mauna Kea that made me reach for my phone just to keep up.

I thought: this kid should completely lose his mind in Hawaii. And then: how do I actually make sure that happens, instead of just hoping it does?

I looked for tools. Nothing existed. So I started building. Four more trips — New York, Chicago, Saint Louis, Omaha — and a lot of honest feedback from Avir and Aarit later, something finally worked.

Here is what I found:

G

GET CURIOUS

Before you arrive

Plant a question, not a fact. Three days before, not three minutes before.

P

PLAY THE STOP

While you're there

Give your child a mission. Then get out of the way.

S

SAVE THE MEMORY

Before it fades

The memory doesn't save itself. Five minutes at the end of each day.

Three steps. Any trip. Any age. The rest of this book shows you how.

CHAPTER 02

Why Family Travel Is Secretly Broken

The hidden tax on every family trip.

The vacation isn't actually a vacation anymore. Not for parents. Not really.

You took time off, spent real money, packed bags, built an itinerary — and somewhere between the airport and the third meltdown before lunch, it stopped feeling like a break and started feeling like a different kind of exhausting.

You're standing in front of something genuinely incredible — a fort, a waterfall, a city skyline — and one kid is sitting on the ground refusing to walk and the other one needs a snack and nobody is looking at the thing you drove two hours to see.

A lot of parents quietly admit: I feel like I'm running a travelling daycare instead of a family.

Most don't say it out loud, because we're supposed to be grateful. So you swallow it. You take a photo to prove it was fine. But the quiet frustration is real — and it has a specific weight: the trip has to be worth it.

The Real Problem

When a trip falls apart, parents tend to blame the kids, the destination, or the planning. Sometimes true. Mostly not the real problem. The real problem is structural.

Travel is designed for adults. Itineraries, apps, guides — all built around adult priorities. Kids don't experience places the way adults do. Adults feel the weight of five hundred years at the Amber Fort. Children see a really big building — unless something connects them to it. A mission. A question. A reason to look.

Kids are passengers, not participants. When a child has no role at a stop — nothing to find, nothing to figure out — they disengage. Not because they're difficult. Because disengagement is the rational response to having nothing to do.

The Memory Problem

Kids don't remember the places unless something happens there. This isn't kids being kids — it's how memory actually works. We don't retain catalogues. We retain moments — specific, surprising, emotionally charged moments.

The photo that proves you were at the fort doesn't create a memory. The moment that catches a child genuinely by surprise — that's the memory.

We spend all our planning time on the places, and almost no time on the moments. That's the gap the GPS Method closes.

CHAPTER 03

What Actually Makes Kids Light Up on Trips

Curiosity. Role. Space.

Avir was six the first time I watched him completely lose track of time somewhere that wasn't a screen.

We were at The Field Museum in Chicago. Before we walked through the door, I told him one thing:

"There's a fossil in here that's older than the dinosaurs. See if you can figure out which one it is."

He spent the next hour and forty minutes moving through that museum like a detective. He read the placards — actually read them, lips moving slightly. He asked a staff member two questions I couldn't have answered. He doubled back twice to check something he'd missed.

When he found what he was looking for — a trilobite fossil — he turned around and looked at me with an expression I don't have a word for. Somewhere between vindication and awe.

The night before, we told him there was a fossil in this museum older than the dinosaurs. See if you can find it. He spent the next ninety minutes moving through like a detective. That's the G in GPS.



The night before, we told Avir there was a fossil in this museum older than the dinosaurs. See if you can find it. He spent the next ninety minutes moving through like a detective. That's the G in GPS.

He still talks about that museum. That was two years ago.

Aarit, three and a half on that trip, spent the same ninety minutes trying to touch everything with a 'do not touch' sign. Also relevant data. Just a different kind.

Kids don't light up when they're told things. They light up when they're trying to figure something out.

Three Things That Actually Work

A question, not a fact. Before Chicago, I could have said 'there are fossils older than dinosaurs in here.' Avir would have nodded and walked through like he walked through the Amber Fort — politely, from a distance. Instead I made him the detective. The museum became the crime scene.

Try it at any destination:

- “How many windows do you think this fort has?”
- “Can you find something in this market that wasn’t here a hundred years ago?”
- What do you think this building was before it became a museum?”

A role that is real. Aarit is the family photographer. He's four. He takes blurry photos of things at knee-height with the seriousness of a professional. And on days when he has that role, he's measurably more present than on days when he doesn't. Avir is the navigator. He holds the map, calls the turns, announces how far we are from the next stop. This sounds small. It is not small.

Space. The worst thing you can do when a child is finally engaged is fill that engagement with more input. When Avir was working through that museum, I stayed close enough to answer a question if he asked one. Mostly I stayed quiet. There's a moment, right when a child's eyes go to something, where the best thing you can do is nothing. Let the curiosity breathe.

Aarit will not remember The Field Museum. He'll remember the revolving door at the entrance, which he went through six times while my wife and I waited. Avir will remember the trilobite - the moment of finding it, not the placard.

"Why do we spend all our planning time on places?"

The real question is: how do we plan the moments?

CHAPTER 04

The GPS Method

Get Curious. Play the Stop. Save the Memory.

When you're lost in a new city, GPS doesn't overwhelm you with the entire map. It gives you one instruction at a time — knowing where you are, where you're going, and what you need right now, which is never everything at once.

That's what I wanted for family travel. Not a better itinerary. A navigation system — something that handles the before, the during, and the after, without requiring you to hold it all in your head while managing snacks and sunscreen and a four-year-old who needs a bathroom.

G GET CURIOUS

Before you arrive

The biggest mistake families make is starting the trip at the destination. You arrive and try to explain why this place is worth attention — competing with exhaustion and the disorientation of somewhere new. You've already lost.

The G in GPS moves the starting line three days earlier. Not with information — with a question. The night before Hawaii, I asked Avir: 'Mauna Kea is the tallest mountain in the world if you measure from its base. But people don't call it that. Why do you think that is?' He thought about it for two days. One question. A mystery beats a fact every time.

P PLAY THE STOP

While you're there

Mostly about what not to do. Don't explain too much. Don't rush. Don't turn their curiosity into a lesson. Give your child a mission before you get out of the car — then get out of the way.

In Saint Louis, Avir was in deep conversation with a ranger at the Gateway Arch — locked in, completely present. I pulled him away to stay on schedule. The mood shifted and never quite came back. I've never done that again.

S SAVE THE MEMORY

Before it fades

The memory doesn't save itself. We take photos, buy a magnet, check in on social media — and go home with hundreds of pictures of places and almost no record of what our kids actually felt or said or discovered.

Three questions at the end of each day:

"What surprised you most today?" Surprise signals something broke through.

"What did you figure out that you didn't know this morning?"

Write one thing they said, exactly as they said it. Voice memo it. Ten seconds. You will not remember it accurately in a week.

"The volcano smells like when you strike a match but bigger?"
— *Avir, age 7 · Hawaii trip*

No photograph captures that. Write it down immediately. You will not remember it accurately in a week.

That's the GPS Method. Before, during, after. Not a revolution - a framework that makes sure your kids arrive curious, stay engaged, and leave with something real.

CHAPTER 05

What Other Parents Said.

Real families. Real moments. Real words.

I've been talking to parents about this for a long time. But recently I posted a question in a few family travel communities online - not about the app, just about the problem. How do you handle the mid-trip execution gap? What actually falls apart?

Hundreds of parents replied. What struck me wasn't the variety of answers. It was how much they agreed. Different cities, different ages, different family configurations - the same things kept coming up.

Here is what they actually said:

On energy, not itinerary

The most upvoted comment in the thread was three words: "Kids getting hangry." Hundreds of parents immediately recognised it.

What followed was a cascade of the same insight from different directions. Most families that aren't having fun aren't having fun because the kids are overstimulated or tired. Not because the destination was wrong. Not because the planning was bad.

One parent said it best: the problem isn't finding the right activities, it's the right rhythm. Active time and restorative time. And almost no travel advice talks about the ratio - only the content.

"Your biggest issue might be that you have a stop 2 even before lunch. Are you overscheduling?"

— Parent · [r/familytravel](#)

On unplanned moments

One parent described a trip where they had a forest trail planned. They stopped at a village square and found an oversized chess set. Two kids who suddenly had no interest in the forest trail. They played for two hours. Locals stopped to watch. Someone explained the rules in Norwegian. It became one of the best afternoons of the whole trip.

They could have walked past it in thirty seconds.

The insight that stayed with me: the gap between planned and actual closes a lot when you stop treating the detour as a problem.

The trips that actually worked weren't the ones where we executed the itinerary. They were the ones where we stopped when something caught their attention and stayed until they were done.— Parent · r/familytravel

On memory

One parent gave their kids a small travel journal - not to document the itinerary, but to write down or sketch whatever surprised them that day. A chess game in Norway made it in. The forest trail they skipped didn't.

That says everything about what actually mattered.

But the part that stopped me: the kids kept going back to read it after they got home. Same enthusiasm as scrolling through photos. Sometimes more.

We don't retain catalogues. We retain moments. The journal caught the moments. The photos caught the places.

“What really blew my mind was how often they went back to read it after the trip. Same enthusiasm as scrolling through photos. Sometimes more.”
— Parent · r/familytravel

Kids rarely remember the stop adults thought was important. They remember how a place felt. That changes how you plan everything.

It stops being: what should we see? It becomes: what do we want to feel? That's the question the GPS Method is built to answer.

10 Things You Can Do On Your Next Trip

Practical. No app required.

Everything here can be done without an app, without research, and without changing your plans. Small moves. Try at least three before deciding they don't matter.

1.. Ask the question the night before.

Not: 'Are you excited for tomorrow?' Instead: 'Tomorrow we're going to see _____. What's one thing you want to figure out while we're there?' If they're blank, offer a mystery. Ninety seconds. It changes the entire morning.

2.. Give each kid a role before you get out of the car.

Photographer. Navigator. Question-asker who has to talk to someone who works there. Kids with a job before they walk in arrive differently.

3.. Build in one stop with no agenda.

A park, a market, a side street that looks interesting. Watch what they find. It will almost certainly be something you would have walked past.

4.. Let one child make one real decision.

Not 'left or right?' A real choice: 'We can do the fort first or the market first — you pick.' Ownership produces engagement.

5.. When a child locks onto something unexpected — stop.

Aarit and the water fountain. Six trips through a revolving door. When a child gets genuinely curious about something unplanned, give them five minutes. The fort will still be there.

6.. Replace one explanation with one question.

'This building is three hundred years old' gets a nod. 'If this building could talk, what do you think it would complain about?' gets a child who is now thinking about the building.

7.. End every day with three questions — not one.

'What surprised you today? What do you want to know more about? What should we do differently tomorrow?' A child asked how to improve the trip feels like a collaborator, not a passenger.

8.. Write down one thing your kid says, exactly as they said it.

Voice memo it. Ten seconds. You will not remember it accurately in a week. These are the things that matter in twenty years.

9.. Cut one thing from tomorrow's plan tonight.

Find the stop on the list because it's supposed to be there, not because anyone is excited about it. Cut it. Use that time as buffer.

10.. Take one photo your kids will recognise as theirs.

Hand them the phone: 'Take one photo today that shows what this trip feels like to you.' In ten years you'll have a collection taken from three feet off the ground, at strange angles, of things you'd never have noticed.

Three of these. This weekend. A question the night before, a role before you get out of the car, and one moment where you stop managing the day and let something happen.

CHAPTER 07

Why I Built RoamUs

The honest founder story.

Back to Hawaii.

Not the volcano or Mauna Kea or the cloud forest Avir had been reading about for three months. Back to the kitchen table at our rental house, the week before we flew out, trying to figure out how to make this trip actually work for my kids.

I had the rough shape of the GPS Method by then. I knew I needed curiosity questions before we arrived. I knew I needed roles at each stop. I knew memories don't save themselves. What I didn't have was any help doing it.

I spent three evenings researching Avir's interests — volcanoes, lava types, ocean depth, the specific geology of the Big Island — building questions that would actually mean something to him specifically. Wikipedia. A YouTube documentary about Kilauea I made my wife watch at midnight, while the kids slept. It took longer than planning the logistics had.



Kilauea, Hawaii. That night, Avir said the volcano smelled like when you strike a match but bigger. He was right. That's the kind of thing you write down immediately.

There are millions of parents doing this exact thing right now. Caring enough. Willing to put in the hours. But doing it from scratch, every trip, with no system and no support. There had to be a better way.

I looked seriously for tools. Nothing was built for this — for a particular child with particular interests, at a particular place, in a way that got out of the way once you arrived and helped capture what happened after.

So I built it. And I'll be honest, the first version was too clever. Too many prompts. Too much structure. Avir ignored it in ten minutes. Kids are the most unforgiving product testers in existence. Back to the drawing board. Four test trips. Most things failed the first time. Some failed the second. But something repeatable finally emerged.

That became RoamUs.



Cloud forest mission, Hawaii. Avir's task: find a tree that only grows on this island and figure out why. Aarit's task: keep up.

What RoamUs Actually Does

Before your trip, it learns about your children - ages, interests, what makes them lean in, and builds the G: curiosity questions specific to your child, not generic to the destination.

At each stop, it runs the P: a mission, age-appropriate, that gets out of the way once they're engaged. It doesn't ask you to stare at a screen while you're somewhere worth looking at.

After each stop, it captures the S automatically, what your kids said, what surprised them, what they discovered. Over a trip it builds something that is part travel journal, part memory archive, part record of who your children were at this age in this place.

You don't need RoamUs to have a better family trip. I mean that. Everything in this book works without an app. The question the night before. The role before you get out of the car. The three questions at dinner. None of that requires a phone.

What RoamUs does is make it easier to do consistently - across a whole trip, not just the one stop where you remembered to try. And it handles the research that took me three evenings before Hawaii, so you don't have to.

Try it free on your next trip at roamus.app.

BONUS SECTION

25 Things That Actually Work.

From parents who travel with kids under 12. No theory. Just what works.

These come from hundreds of parents in family travel communities. Not travel bloggers. Not parenting experts. Parents who have had the exact same bad afternoon you've had, figured something out, and wrote it down. Some of them might be repeated from the section above, but I definitely think it's important enough.

B BEFORE YOU LEAVE

The work that actually pays off

1. Ask one question the night before. Not 'are you excited?' — a mystery.

"There's a fossil in this museum older than the dinosaurs. See if you can find it." They'll be thinking about it on the drive. That's the whole point.

2. Show them pictures of where you're going and let them veto things.

One parent showed their daughter castle pictures before Scotland and let her choose which ones to visit. She arrived already curious about her specific castles, not castles in general.

3. Book one base for the whole trip. Don't move hotels every two nights.

The check-in/check-out overhead with young kids is exhausting in a way that sneaks up on you. Moving loses most of a day. Three nights minimum, five is better.

4. Cut one thing from tomorrow's plan tonight.

Find the stop that's on the list because it's supposed to be there, not because anyone is actually excited about it. Cut it. Use that time as buffer.

5. Know what your specific kid will happily do and plan around that.

Arcades. Cannons. Prison cells. Anything with buttons. Junior Ranger badges at national parks. Every kid has their thing. Lean into it without apology.

D DURING THE DAY

What actually keeps things from falling apart

6. One main stop per day. Everything else is flexible.

One non-negotiable per chunk of day. Build everything else around it using things you're willing to drop. The one thing stays. Everything else breathes.

7. Hit must-sees early. Go soft in the middle. Never plan a day with everyone on their feet all day.

Morning is your window. Crowds are lowest, energy is highest. After lunch, go light. Gardens, parks, a boat tour, street food.

8. Give each kid a role before getting out of the car.

Photographer. Navigator. Question-asker who has to talk to one person who works there. Kids with a job before they walk in arrive differently.

9. When a child locks onto something unexpected, stop.

The water fountain. Six trips through a revolving door. When a child gets genuinely curious about something unplanned, give them five minutes. The fort will still be there.

10. Replace one explanation with one question.

"This building is three hundred years old" gets a nod. "If this building could talk, what do you think it would complain about?" gets a child who is now thinking about the building.

11. Let one child make one real decision.

Not 'left or right?' A real choice: 'We can do the fort first or the market first — you pick.' The sequence may not matter to you. It will matter to them.

12. Build in a rest stop. Not a loose hour — actual empty space with no fallback plan.

A park with a playground. A picnic in the grass. When kids know there's nothing they're missing, they stop rushing. So do you.

13. Never go past the snack window.

You will trace mood collapses back to a missed snack at 11am like clockwork. Carry more than you think you need. Stop before anyone asks.

14. Sit-down lunch. Quick dinner.

A real lunch where everyone sits and eats and nobody is walking anywhere is the thing that saves the afternoon. Dinner when everyone is tired can be takeout or snacks.

15. Become YES parents. Within reason.

Ice cream every afternoon — sure. Pancakes at 4:30pm — why not. The trips where you say yes to the weird detour are almost always the ones that feel most alive.

16. It's okay to split up sometimes.

One parent takes the younger kids to a nearby park while the other stays at the museum with the older one. Two parallel trips that each work, instead of one compromise that doesn't.

17. The attitude moment is coming. Accept it before the trip starts.

Someone will have an attitude. It doesn't mean the trip is broken. You acknowledge it and move on. The expectation that it will be perfect is where most trip stress comes from.

18. Plan a day off. Completely off.

Videogames and pizza in jammies. A beach day with no agenda. Let kids decide and recuperate. This is not wasting a trip day. It is what makes the rest of the trip possible.

E END OF DAY

The five minutes that make the whole trip stick

19. End every day with three questions. Not one.

'What surprised you today? What do you want to know more about? What should we do differently tomorrow?' A child asked how to improve the trip feels like a collaborator, not a passenger.

20. Write down one thing your kid said, exactly as they said it. Voice memo it.

'The volcano smells like when you strike a match but bigger.' Not a summary. The actual words. You will not remember it accurately in a week.

21. Let your kid take one photo that shows what the trip feels like to them.

Hand them the phone. In ten years you'll have a collection taken from three feet off the ground, at strange angles, of things you'd never have noticed.

22. Don't review the day's photos until the trip is over.

Looking at photos mid-trip pulls you out of the trip. Save it for the flight home.

+ WORTH SAYING PLAINLY

The things nobody puts in travel guides

23. You're just parenting in a different location.

If your kid gets grumpy when tired at home, they will get grumpy when tired on vacation. Travel like you know your kid, not like you hope they'll be different.

24. Travel like you will return.

The Vatican Museums can wait until your youngest is eight. Rome is the Eternal City. Immersion in a place is more memorable than a speed run through historical sites.

25. The bad moments are as fleeting as the good ones. Sometimes they become the best stories.

The day we spent forty-five minutes negotiating with a toddler about a water fountain outside a five-hundred-year-old fort is the story we tell most. Not the fort. The water fountain. The mess is the memory.



Try it free on your next trip.

Set up takes five minutes. Tell us your kids' ages and what they're into. RoamUs builds the curiosity questions, runs the missions at every stop, and captures the trip story — so you can stay present while it handles the rest.

roamus.app

The trip you're imagining is possible — the real one, not the Instagram version. Where your child turns around at a geyser with their arms out. Or tells you the volcano smells like matches but bigger. Those moments exist. They just need a little room to happen.

Go make some room.

— A parent, figuring it out one trip at a time